

History of Medieval Bengal

Sultanate period

An overview of Medieval Bengal

- 1) The medieval history of Bengal spans from approximately 1200 CE to 1768 CE, beginning with the establishment of Muslim rule and concluding with the grant of Diwani to the East India Company.
- 2) This period witnessed the absorption of Bengal into the Delhi Sultanate, followed by independent Bengal Sultanate, and rule by various dynasties, culminating in Mughal conquest.

Bengal under Delhi Sultanate

- ▶ Early Muslim Rule (c. 1200-1342): Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji conquered northwestern Bengal around 1204, initiating the period of Muslim rule under the Delhi Sultanate. Although initially under direct control, the vast distance made governance challenging, and Bengal experienced periods of semi-autonomy or local rule.
- ▶ Until the middle of 14th century three breakaway sultanates emerged in Delhi Sultanate province of Bengal. This included a realm led by Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah and later his son in Sonargaon, A realm led by Alauddin Ali Shah in Gouda(also called Lakhnauti), and a realm led by Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah in Satgaon.
- ▶ Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta visited Sonargaon during the reign of Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah. He also visited Sufi Hazrat Shah Jalal (R) in Sylhet.

Independent Bengal Sultanate (1342-1538)

- ▶ Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah united various parts of Bengal and founded the independent Bengal Sultanate in 1342, establishing a more centralized administration. He then proclaimed himself as Shah-a-Bangala. This era saw the rule of dynasties like the Ilyas Shahi (1342-1487) and the Hussain Shahi dynasty (1493-1538), the latter known for its territorial expansion.
- ▶ The Ilyas Shahi reign was interrupted by an uprising orchestrated by the sultan's premier Raja Ganesha, a Hindu aristocrat. Ganesha installed his son Jadu to the throne but his son was influenced to convert to Islam by the court's Sufi clergy. Jadu took the title of Jalaluddin Muhammad Shah.
- ▶ Habshi rule :The rule of the Habshis (Abyssinians) in Bengal lasted nearly six years (893 AH/ 1487 AD to 899 AH /1493 AD), during which four rulers (Barbak Shah Shahzada, Saifuddin Firuz Shah, Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah II and Shamsuddin Muzaffar Shah ruled Bengal.
- ▶ Ala-ud-din Husain Shah was an independent late medieval Sultan of the Bengal Sultanate, who founded the Hussain Shahi dynasty. He became the ruler of Bengal after assassinating the Abyssinian Sultan, Shams-ud-Din Muzaffar Shah, whom he had served under as wazir. After his death in 1519, his son Nusrat Shah succeeded him. The reigns of Husain Shah and Nusrat Shah are generally regarded as the "golden age" of the Bengal Sultanate. Husain Shah patronized Bengali culture and language. During his time, Ramayana and Mahabharat was translated into Bangla. Moreover, Sri Chaitanya introduced Gaudiya Vaishnavism, a Hindu religious movement, during this time. Bijay Gupta wrote his Manasamangal Kāvya

Cultural and Social Developments

- ▶ Language and Literature: Bengali language evolved from Sanskrit, with significant influences from Persian and Arabic during the medieval period, leading to rich literary traditions, including religious scriptures, epics, and secular works.
- ▶ Architecture: While early medieval Bengal was influenced by Buddhist architectural styles during the Pala Empire, later periods saw the development of distinct architectural styles under the Sultanate. Considerable architectural projects were undertaken which induced the influence of Persian architecture, Arab architecture and Byzantine architecture in Bengal. The dynasty was a promoter of Indo-Persian culture. One of the sultans, Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah, kept a correspondence with the renowned Persian poet Hafez.
- ▶ Trade and Commerce: The Bengal Sultanate was a major trading nation, engaging in extensive maritime trade. The arrival of early Portuguese merchants also marked this era.



Sonargaon was the capital of the Bengal Sultanate under the reign of Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah. It hosted a royal court and mint of the Bengal Sultanate, and was also the center of the muslin trade in Bengal, with a large population of weavers and artisans. Currently, Sonargaon is one of the historical sites that draws many tourists each year in Bangladesh.